

The Complete Financial Guide for Young Couples

and with them, land prices collapsed. The debt on many farms exceeded their total value, sometimes by a factor of three or four to one. Bankers, panicked by the turn of events, cut off all credit and farmers couldn't even plant for the next season.

Thousands of families were evicted and farms that had been in the same families for generations were auctioned off for a fraction of their accumulated debt. Any one of those families would have been thrilled to go back to where they began, but it was too late. Their problem was not stupidity. Most are very intelligent people with good academic educations. Their problem was ignorance: a lack of understanding. They had been taught well, but they had been taught the wrong things.

This same fundamental error is being repeated in millions of young families today. They build too much too quickly, using too much debt, and when they hit a down stretch—and everybody does eventually—they get wiped out just like the farmers.

Let me make it very clear: we have been taught false principles by the world in which we live. The plumb line for truth is God's Word, not a college textbook or a standard practice.

God's Word teaches a set of principles most of us haven't heard in the media or in the classroom. For example, what is the first thing that comes to your mind when I say, "There goes a very wealthy person"? You visualize someone with a surplus of money, large cars, maybe a large business, certainly a large home. That's the normal image of wealth in our society. But when God's Word describes a wealthy person, it never makes reference to the amount of money he has. God's Word says that wealth is more than money. Wealth is everything that you and I have as Christians.

It is, number one, salvation, because that is our greatest wealth from God. It never ends. Secondly, the friends that we have are part of our wealth from God. Our children are a part of our inheritance. Even the relationship between a husband and wife (in the Lord) is a part of our wealth from God.

So as you evaluate the difference between God's wealth and the world's wealth, you begin to realize that God promises